

Word family: **meal / meals / mealtime / mealy / mealiness**

This family needs an important split at the outset: modern English has **meal¹ = an eating occasion / the food eaten**, and **meal² = a coarse ground substance**, as in **cornmeal, bone meal, fish meal**. Historically, these come from different roots and should not be forced into one semantic core. ([詞源網絡詞典][1])

Base word: meal

Plural: meals

Part of speech: noun (名詞)

Major related/compound forms:

- * mealtime
- * meal plan
- * meal planning
- * meal prep
- * meal preparation
- * meal service
- * meal delivery
- * meal kit
- * ready meal
- * frozen meal
- * microwave meal
- * set meal
- * family meal
- * school meal
- * staff meal
- * children's meal
- * meal deal
- * meal break
- * meal period
- * meal allowance
- * meal voucher
- * meal ticket
- * meal replacement
- * square meal
- * three-course meal
- * one-course meal
- * multi-course meal
- * light meal
- * heavy meal
- * main meal
- * shared meal
- * communal meal
- * ceremonial meal

- * cornmeal
- * oatmeal
- * maize meal
- * wholemeal
- * bone meal
- * blood meal
- * fish meal
- * soybean meal
- * oilseed meal
- * meat-and-bone meal
- * mealworm
- * mealy
- * mealiness
- * mealy-mouthed

Your passage:

> “...calculate how many cups of coffee and **meals** you must sell each day to break even.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **meal** means:

> **a substantial serving or combination of prepared food that a customer buys and eats as breakfast, lunch, dinner, etc.**

The writer is asking Kam Chai to calculate his necessary daily sales volume:

> number of coffees + number of meals sold.

繁體中文：

餐

膳食

一份正餐

* in this commercial context: **餐點 / 餐食**

A natural translation is:

> “calculate how many cups of coffee and meals you must sell each day”

「計算每天必須賣出多少杯咖啡和多少份餐點。」

Here **meal** does not mean one individual dish in every possible case. It means food sold as something substantial enough to constitute a customer's meal.

A. MEAL = OCCASION WHEN FOOD IS EATEN

1. **meal = an occasion when people eat (用餐 ; 一餐) **

One of the two central everyday senses.

> “We usually have three meals a day.”

「我們通常每天吃**三餐**。」

> “Breakfast is my favourite meal.”

「早餐是我最喜歡的**一餐**。」

Cambridge defines **meal** as either the occasion when food is eaten or the food eaten on that occasion. ([劍橋詞典][2])

B. MEAL = THE FOOD EATEN AT THAT OCCASION

2. **meal = food eaten at one eating occasion (一頓飯 ; 膳食) **

> “That was an excellent meal.”

「那是很棒的**一頓飯**。」

Here **meal** refers to:

> the food itself,

not merely the time at which it was eaten.

C. OCCASION VS FOOD

Compare:

> “Dinner is our main **meal**.”

= dinner as an **eating occasion**.

versus:

> “The **meal** was delicious.”

= the **food served/eaten**.

Same lexical branch, different focus.

D. HAVE / EAT A MEAL

3. **have a meal** = 吃一頓飯

> “Let's have a meal before we leave.”

「我們出發前先**吃點東西 / 吃一頓飯**。」

4. **eat a meal** = 吃一餐

> “He ate a large meal.”

「他吃了一頓**很豐富的飯**。」

E. COOK / PREPARE A MEAL

5. **prepare a meal** = 準備一餐

> “She prepared a meal for the family.”

「她為家人**準備了一頓飯**。」

6. **cook a meal** = 煮一頓飯

F. SERVE A MEAL

7. **serve a meal** = 供應 / 端上一餐

> “The airline served a hot meal.”

「航空公司供應了一份****熱食餐點****。」

G. ORDER A MEAL

8. ****order a meal = 點餐 / 點一份正餐****

> “We ordered a meal before the film.”

「我們在電影開始前點了一份餐。」

H. BUY / SELL MEALS

9. ****sell meals = 售賣餐食 / 膳食****

This is your passage construction.

A café may sell:

- * drinks;
- * snacks;
- * individual dishes;
- * complete meals.

I. SKIP A MEAL

10. ****skip a meal = 不吃某一餐 ; 少吃一餐****

> “I skipped lunch.”

= “I skipped a meal.”

「我****沒有吃午餐****。」

J. MISS A MEAL

11. ****miss a meal = 因故沒吃一餐****

Close to **skip**, but:

skip a meal

can suggest deliberate omission.

miss a meal

often suggests circumstances prevented it.

K. BETWEEN MEALS

12. **between meals** = 兩餐之間

> “Try not to snack between meals.”

「盡量不要在**兩餐之間**吃零食。」

L. BEFORE / AFTER MEALS

13. **before meals** = 飯前

14. **after meals** = 飯後

Common especially in:

* medicine instructions;

* dietary advice.

M. AT MEALS / AT MEALTIME

15. **at meals** = 用餐時

> “They usually talk at meals.”

「他們通常在**吃飯時**聊天。」

N. MEALTIME

16. **mealtime** = usual/specified time at which a meal is eaten (用餐時間)

> “No phones at mealtimes.”

「**用餐時間**不要使用電話。」

Mealtime is historically rather interesting because **meal** itself originally referred to an appointed time/opportunity; the compound therefore repeats that time idea etymologically. ([詞源網絡詞典][3])

O. BREAKFAST / LUNCH / DINNER AS MEALS

17. **breakfast** = morning meal

18. **lunch** = midday meal

19. **dinner** = major/evening meal depending on culture/context

These are specific kinds of **meal**.

P. MAIN MEAL

20. **main meal** = largest/most substantial meal of the day (主餐)

> “Their main meal is in the evening.”

「他們一天中的**主餐**在晚上。」

Cambridge explicitly records this construction. ([劍橋詞典][2])

Q. MIDDAY / EVENING MEAL

21. **midday meal** = 午間的一餐

Formal/general term where cultural labels such as **lunch/dinner** might vary.

22. **evening meal** = 晚餐

Similarly neutral.

R. HOT MEAL

23. **hot meal = 熱食餐 / 熱餐**

A meal served hot rather than consisting only of cold foods.

> “The shelter provides hot meals.”

「收容機構提供**熱食**。」

Cambridge uses **hot meal** as a standard example. ([劍橋詞典][2])

S. COLD MEAL

24. **cold meal = 冷餐**

Food eaten without being served hot.

T. LIGHT MEAL

25. **light meal = 較清淡 / 份量較少的一餐**

> “We had a light meal before the concert.”

「音樂會前我們吃了一頓較**輕便的餐食**。」

Cambridge explicitly contrasts light and heavy meals. ([劍橋詞典][2])

U. HEAVY MEAL

26. **heavy meal = 豐盛 / 較難消化的大餐**

Usually:

* large;

* rich;
* filling.

> “Avoid a heavy meal just before exercise.”

「運動前不要吃太**豐盛的一餐**。」

V. BIG / LARGE MEAL

27. **large meal = 份量很大的一餐**

Focuses primarily on quantity.

Heavy meal may additionally suggest:

> rich/fatty/difficult to digest.

W. SUBSTANTIAL MEAL

28. **substantial meal = 份量足、能令人飽足的一餐**

Formal.

X. FULL MEAL

29. **full meal = 完整的一餐 / 正餐**

Usually more substantial than:

* snack;
* drink;
* small bite.

Y. SQUARE MEAL

30. **square meal = substantial, satisfying, nutritionally adequate meal (飽足的一餐 ; 像樣的正餐)**

> “He hadn’t had a square meal in days.”

「他好幾天沒有好好吃過一頓****飽飯****。」

This does ****not**** refer to the geometric shape of the food.

Cambridge lists ****a square meal**** as an established expression. ([劍橋詞典][4])

Z. DECENT MEAL

31. ****decent meal = 像樣的一餐****

Informal/general.

> enough food of acceptable quality.

AA. BALANCED MEAL

32. ****balanced meal = 營養較均衡的一餐****

A meal containing a suitable balance of different food components according to the nutritional framework being used.

AB. HEALTHY MEAL

33. ****healthy meal = 健康膳食****

Broad everyday term; exact nutritional criteria depend on context.

AC. HOME-COOKED MEAL

34. ****home-cooked meal = 家常 / 在家烹調的一餐****

Often carries positive associations:

- * fresh;
- * personal;
- * comforting.

But the phrase itself does not guarantee nutritional quality.

AD. RESTAURANT MEAL

35. **restaurant meal = 在餐廳吃的一餐**

AE. FAST-FOOD MEAL

36. **fast-food meal = 快餐**

Often a bundled food offering from a fast-food restaurant.

AF. THREE-COURSE MEAL

37. **three-course meal = 三道菜的一餐**

Typically some combination such as:

- * starter

- * main course

- * dessert.

Cambridge uses **three-course meal** as a standard example. ([劍橋詞典][2])

AG. MULTI-COURSE MEAL

38. **multi-course meal = 多道菜餐**

A meal consisting of several sequential courses.

AH. ONE-POT MEAL

39. **one-pot meal = 一鍋完成的完整餐食**

All or most components are cooked together in one cooking vessel.

AI. FAMILY MEAL — HOUSEHOLD

40. **family meal = 一家人共同吃的一餐**

> “Sunday dinner is an important family meal.”

「星期日晚餐是重要的**家庭聚餐**。」

AJ. FAMILY MEAL — RESTAURANT INDUSTRY

41. **family meal = restaurant staff meal eaten before/between service (員工餐) **

In restaurant culture, **family meal** can refer to:

> food prepared for restaurant staff to eat together.

This is an independently useful hospitality sense.

AK. STAFF MEAL

42. **staff meal = 員工餐**

Meal supplied to employees during/before a shift.

AL. SHARED / COMMUNAL MEAL

43. **shared meal = 共餐**

44. **communal meal = 集體共餐**

The social act of eating together is emphasized.

AM. FESTIVE / CEREMONIAL MEAL

45. **festive meal = 節慶大餐**

46. **ceremonial meal = 儀式性餐食**

Meals may play important roles in:

- * religious observance;
- * festivals;
- * weddings;
- * funerals;
- * community rituals.

AN. READY MEAL

47. **ready meal = 預先製成、只需加熱或簡單處理即可食用的餐食**

Especially BrE.

> “I heated a ready meal.”

「我加熱了一份**即食 / 預製餐**。」

Often sold refrigerated or frozen.

AO. FROZEN MEAL

48. **frozen meal = 冷凍餐**

Prepared meal sold frozen for later heating.

AP. MICROWAVE MEAL

49. **microwave meal = 微波即食餐**

A prepared meal designed mainly for microwave reheating.

AQ. PREPACKAGED / PREPARED MEAL

50. **prepackaged meal = 預先包裝的餐食**

51. **prepared meal = 預製餐食**

AR. MEAL KIT

52. **meal kit = 食材包 / 料理包**

A package containing:

- * measured ingredients;
- * recipe/instructions,

for preparing a particular meal at home.

Important distinction:

> **meal kit ≠ ready meal**

A meal kit generally still requires cooking/assembly.

AS. MEAL PREP

53. **meal prep = 預先備餐**

Informal shortening of:

> meal preparation.

Usually means preparing:

- * several meals;
- * ingredients;
- * portions

in advance.

AT. MEAL PREPARATION

54. **meal preparation = 膳食準備**

Broader/formal term.

Can mean ordinary cooking or systematic advance preparation.

AU. MEAL PLANNING

55. **meal planning = 膳食規劃**

Deciding in advance:

- * which meals to eat/serve;
- * ingredients;
- * portions;
- * timing.

AV. MEAL PLAN — DIETARY

56. **meal plan = 膳食計劃**

A structured schedule/list of meals for:

- * a day;
- * week;
- * dietary objective.

AW. MEAL PLAN — UNIVERSITY/HOTEL/DINING

57. **meal plan = prepaid/package arrangement entitling someone to specified meals (膳食方案 / 餐飲計劃) **

Especially:

- * university halls;
- * boarding institutions;
- * resorts.

Example:

> “The residence fee includes a meal plan.”

「宿舍費包括****膳食計劃****。」

This is a distinct institutional sense from a diet schedule.

AX. MEAL SERVICE

58. ****meal service = 膳食供應服務****

Can refer to:

- * hospital;
- * airline;
- * school;
- * care home;
- * catering.

AY. MEAL DELIVERY

59. ****meal delivery = 餐食配送****

Could mean:

- * restaurant delivery;
- * prepared-meal subscription;
- * social-care delivery.

AZ. MEALS ON WHEELS

60. ****Meals on Wheels / meals-on-wheels = 為有需要人士送餐的服務****

A conventional phrase for schemes delivering prepared meals to people who have difficulty obtaining or preparing their own food, especially older or housebound people.

The phrase in this social-service sense has been attested since the mid-20th century. ([詞源網絡詞典][1])

Exact programme names/eligibility vary by place.

BA. MEAL REPLACEMENT

61. **meal replacement = intended substitute for an ordinary meal (代餐) **

Examples:

- * meal-replacement shake
- * meal-replacement bar
- * formulated meal product.

It is intended to replace a meal rather than merely accompany one.

BB. MEAL-REPLACEMENT SHAKE

62. **meal-replacement shake = 代餐飲品**

BC. MEAL DEAL

63. **meal deal = fixed-price combination of food/drink items (優惠套餐 / 超值餐組合) **

Especially BrE retail/fast-food usage.

Example:

> sandwich + snack + drink for one combined price.

This is commercial rather than simply “a meal that is a good deal.”

BD. SET MEAL

64. **set meal = 套餐 / 固定餐單**

A predetermined set/limited choice of dishes offered together, usually for a fixed price.

You mapped **menu** previously; compare:

- > **set menu** = the list/offer
- > **set meal** = the actual meal package ordered/eaten.

BE. KIDS' / CHILDREN'S MEAL

65. **children's meal / kids' meal = 兒童餐**

Meal combination designed for children.

BF. BOXED / PACKED MEAL

66. **boxed meal = 盒裝餐**

Prepared meal supplied in a box.

BG. SCHOOL MEAL

67. **school meal = 學校膳食**

A meal provided/eaten at school.

BH. FREE SCHOOL MEAL

68. **free school meal = 免費學校膳食**

Institutional/policy term for a school meal provided without charge to eligible/all pupils under a specified scheme.

Rules vary by jurisdiction.

BI. AIRLINE MEAL

69. **airline meal = 航空餐**

A meal served during a flight.

BJ. IN-FLIGHT MEAL

70. **in-flight meal = 機上餐**

BK. HOSPITAL MEAL

71. **hospital meal = 醫院膳食**

May be adapted to dietary/clinical requirements.

BL. MEAL BREAK

72. **meal break = 用餐休息時間**

A break from work to eat.

May have a specific legal/contractual definition depending on jurisdiction.

BM. MEAL PERIOD

73. **meal period = 用餐時段 / 用餐休息期**

More formal employment/legal wording.

BN. MEAL ALLOWANCE

74. **meal allowance = 膳食津貼**

Money given/reimbursed to cover meal expenses under:

- * employment;
- * travel;
- * expense policy.

BO. MEAL EXPENSE

75. **meal expense = 膳食費用**

Business/travel accounting.

BP. MEAL VOUCHER

76. **meal voucher = 餐券**

Voucher exchangeable for:

- * meal;
- * food purchases

under its terms.

BQ. MEAL TICKET — LITERAL

77. **meal ticket = ticket exchangeable for a meal (餐券) **

Especially AmE.

Cambridge records this literal sense. ([劍橋詞典][5])

BR. MEAL TICKET — FIGURATIVE

78. **meal ticket = person/thing relied on as a source of income or livelihood (長期飯票 ; 收入來源) **

> “He saw the contract as his meal ticket.”

「他把那份合約視為自己的**長期收入來源 / 飯票**。」

Cambridge explicitly records this figurative meaning. ([劍橋詞典][5])

It can sound:

- * humorous;
- * cynical;
- * exploitative,

especially if a person is called someone's **meal ticket**.

BS. **A MEAL TICKET FOR LIFE**

79. **meal ticket for life = seemingly secure long-term source of income**

> “A degree is no longer automatically a meal ticket for life.”

Meaning:

> not guaranteed lifelong financial security.

BT. **MAKE A MEAL OF SOMETHING**

80. **make a meal of/out of something = spend unnecessarily much time, effort, fuss, or drama on it (小題大做 ; 把事情搞得過分複雜) **

Especially BrE, informal and disapproving.

> “It's a simple form—don't make a meal of it.”

「只是一張簡單表格，別**小題大做 / 搞得那麼複雜**。」

Cambridge and Collins both explicitly record this idiom. ([柯林斯詞典][6])

No literal eating is involved.

BU. SPORTS: MAKE A MEAL OF A FOUL / TACKLE

81. **make a meal of contact/foul = exaggerate how serious it was**

Especially BrE sports commentary.

> “The player made a meal of the challenge.”

「球員把那次碰撞**誇張得很嚴重**。」

This is simply the idiom applied to sport.

BV. **MAKE A MEAL OUT OF LEFTOVERS**

Be careful: this can also be completely literal.

> “We made a meal out of the leftovers.”

= 「我們用剩菜**做成了一頓飯**。」

So:

literal

turn ingredients into a meal.

idiomatic

make an unnecessarily big fuss/job out of something.

Context decides.

BW. **MAKE A MEAL OF IT** — SOCIAL/LITERAL

82. **make a meal of it = turn an occasion into a proper meal/social eating occasion**

Possible literal use:

> “Rather than just have coffee, let's make a meal of it.”

≈ 「不如不只喝咖啡，乾脆**一起好好吃一頓**。」

This should be distinguished from the British disapproving idiom:

> make a meal **of a task/problem**.

BX. MEAL = COARSELY GROUND MATERIAL

Now the completely separate **meal²** branch.

83. **meal = grain/seed/material ground or crushed into a relatively coarse powder (粗粉；粉粕)**

Cambridge defines this branch as a substance crushed into a rough powder, especially plant seeds ground for food or animal feed. ([劍橋詞典][2])

This noun is generally ****uncountable****.

> “Add cornmeal.”

not normally:

> *add a meal*.

BY. TWO DIFFERENT HISTORICAL WORDS

This distinction is important for your database.

****meal¹ = eating occasion****

comes historically from a word meaning:

> fixed time / occasion.

****meal² = ground substance****

comes from a root meaning:

> grind / crush.

They are historically separate homonyms, despite having the same modern spelling. ([詞源網絡詞典][1])

So I would index them as:

> ****MEAL¹ — 食事 / 一餐****

> ****MEAL² — 粗粉 / 粉粕****

rather than pretending “ground grain” developed metaphorically from “dinner.”

BZ. CORNMEAL

84. ****cornmeal = 玉米粉 (通常比普通麵粉粗) ****

Ground dried maize/corn.

Common in foods such as:

- * cornbread;
- * polenta-type preparations;
- * coatings.

The exact grind can vary.

CA. MAIZE MEAL

85. **maize meal = 玉米粉**

Especially common terminology in parts of Africa and other regions.

Same broad material as ground maize, though grind/product conventions vary.

CB. OATMEAL — GROUND OATS

86. **oatmeal = 燕麥粉 / 燕麥片製品**

Historically the word refers to ground oats: **oat + meal²**. ([詞源網絡詞典][7])

Modern **oatmeal**, especially AmE, also commonly means:

> porridge made from oats.

That secondary polysemy belongs primarily under **oatmeal**, not bare **meal**.

CC. WHOLEMEAL

87. **wholemeal = 全麥的 / 全麥粉 — chiefly BrE**

Used especially in:

- * wholemeal flour
- * wholemeal bread.

Means made using the whole grain rather than highly refined flour.

CD. WHEATMEAL

88. **wheatmeal = 全麥 / 粗磨小麥粉**

Less common than **wholemeal** in everyday modern usage.

CE. RYE / BARLEY MEAL

89. **rye meal / barley meal = 黑麥粗粉 / 大麥粉**

Product terminology, relatively specialized.

CF. MEAL VS FLOUR

Important.

meal

often relatively coarse material produced by grinding.

flour

normally much finer powder used especially in baking.

Historically **meal²** was broad, but modern English often reserves **flour** particularly for finely ground cereal products; the meal/flour boundary varies by ingredient and commercial standard. Etymonline notes that modern **meal** is commonly understood differently from wheat flour. ([詞源 網絡詞典][1])

So:

> cornmeal ≠ automatically corn flour

because **corn flour** has region-dependent meanings and is often much finer.

CG. MEAL = GROUND FEED MATERIAL

90. **meal = ground/crushed material used in animal feed (飼料粉 / 粕)**

Examples:

- * soybean meal
- * fish meal
- * meat meal.

Here it need not be intended for direct human consumption.

CH. SOYBEAN MEAL

91. **soybean meal = 大豆粕 / 豆粕**

Protein-rich material remaining after much of the oil is extracted from soybeans, widely used in animal feed.

CI. OILSEED MEAL

92. **oilseed meal = 油籽粕**

Material remaining after oil extraction from seeds.

Examples:

- * soybean meal;
- * rapeseed/canola meal;
- * sunflower meal.

CJ. CANOLA / RAPESEED MEAL

93. **canola meal / rapeseed meal = 芥花籽粕 / 油菜籽粕**

Animal-feed/by-product terminology.

CK. COTTONSEED MEAL

94. **cottonseed meal = 棉籽粕**

Feed/fertilizer product.

CL. LINSEED / FLAXSEED MEAL

95. **linseed meal / flax meal = 亞麻籽粉 / 亞麻籽粕**

Exact product may vary depending on whether oil has first been extracted.

CM. FISH MEAL

96. **fish meal / fishmeal = 魚粉**

A processed dry product made from fish/fish by-products, commonly used in animal/aquaculture feed.

Here **meal** = ground processed material.

CN. MEAT MEAL

97. **meat meal = 肉粉**

Rendered/processed animal material used primarily in feed under relevant product definitions.

CO. MEAT-AND-BONE MEAL

98. **meat-and-bone meal = 肉骨粉**

Processed product containing animal tissue/bone material.

Regulatory definitions and permitted uses vary by jurisdiction.

CP. BLOOD MEAL

99. **blood meal = 血粉**

Dried powdered animal blood used especially as:

* fertilizer;

* animal-feed ingredient in some contexts.

Do not confuse with:

> an animal taking a **blood meal** from a host,

discussed separately below.

CQ. BONE MEAL

100. **bone meal / bonemeal** = 骨粉

Finely ground animal bone traditionally used particularly as:

* fertilizer;

* feed/mineral product under appropriate regulations.

Cambridge specifically gives **bone meal** as an example of meal². ([劍橋詞典][2])

CR. FEATHER MEAL

101. **feather meal** = 羽毛粉

Processed feathers used as a protein-rich ingredient/fertilizer in specified agricultural contexts.

CS. GLUTEN MEAL

102. **corn gluten meal** = 玉米蛋白粉

Feed/agricultural product derived from corn processing.

Not the same as:

> ordinary cornmeal.

CT. SEED / NUT MEAL

103. **almond meal** = 杏仁粉

Ground almonds, often somewhat coarser than fine almond flour depending on product convention.

104. **hazelnut meal / nut meal**

Ground nuts used in cooking/baking.

Again the **meal vs flour** distinction may depend on grind/coarseness/manufacture.

CU. INSECT / ARTHROPOD: BLOOD MEAL

A separate compositional meaning of the same two words.

105. **a blood meal = blood consumed by a blood-feeding animal (吸食的一頓血)**

In entomology:

> a mosquito may take a blood meal.

Here:

* **blood** = what is eaten;

* **meal¹** = feeding occasion.

This is **not** blood meal powder/fertilizer (**meal²**).

A beautiful example of the two homonyms producing the exact same compound spelling with completely different structures:

blood meal¹

animal's meal consisting of blood.

blood meal²

dried ground/powdered blood product.

CV. MEALWORM

106. **mealworm = 黃粉蟲幼蟲 / 麵包蟲**

Originally named because the larvae infest stored grain/meal; the compound uses **meal²

.
Etymological sources attest **meal-worm** from the 17th century. ([詞源網絡詞典][8])

CW. MEAL BEETLE

107. **meal beetle = 粉甲蟲類**

Beetles associated with stored meal/grain, including species whose larvae are called mealworms.

Specialist zoological/storage-pest terminology.

CX. MEAL MOTH / INDIANMEAL MOTH

108. **Indianmeal moth = 印度穀螟 / 食品蛾**

A common stored-product pest.

This is a lexicalized species/common name; its **meal** relates to grain/flour products, not eating occasions.

CY. MEALY

109. **mealy = resembling/containing meal; powdery or floury (粉質的) **

Historically derived from **meal²

.

Can describe:

- * food texture;
- * surfaces;
- * substances.

CZ. MEALY POTATO

110. **mealy potato = 粉質薯仔 / 口感鬆粉的馬鈴薯**

A potato whose cooked flesh is:

- * dry;
- * fluffy;
- * floury

rather than waxy.

Especially AmE; BrE often uses ****floury potato****.

DA. MEALY APPLE / FRUIT

111. ****mealy fruit = 果肉粉粉的、乾鬆而不爽脆的水果****

Often negative:

> “The apple had become mealy.”

「蘋果的口感已變得****粉粉鬆散****。」

DB. MEALY TEXTURE

112. ****mealy texture = 粉質、乾鬆的質感****

Depending on food, this can be:

- * desirable;
- * undesirable.

DC. MEALINESS

113. ****mealiness = 粉質、乾鬆的口感 / 性質****

> “The variety is valued for its mealiness.”

Context determines whether it is positive or negative.

DD. MEALYBUG

114. **mealybug = 粉蚧**

A plant pest covered with a white waxy/powdery-looking secretion.

Its name uses **mealy** because of that floury appearance.

DE. MEALY-MOUTHED

115. **mealy-mouthed = 不肯直說的；吞吞吐吐而過分委婉的**

An established adjective meaning:

> unwilling to speak plainly or directly, especially because of excessive politeness/caution.

> “Don't be mealy-mouthed—tell me what you think.”

「別再**拐彎抹角 / 吞吞吐吐**，直接說你的看法。」

This is now semantically opaque and should be learned as a fixed word rather than interpreted literally as “a mouth full of meal.”

DF. MEAL TICKET VS FOOD VOUCHER

meal ticket — literal

specific ticket exchangeable for a meal.

meal voucher

broader voucher/coupon covering all or part of meal cost.

meal ticket — figurative

source of income/livelihood.

Only the last is clearly figurative.

DG. MEAL VS FOOD

food

any edible nourishment/substance.

meal

food eaten together at a particular eating occasion.

An apple is food.

One apple is not necessarily a **meal**.

DH. MEAL VS DISH

Critical for your passage.

dish

one particular prepared food.

meal

the overall eating occasion or total food eaten.

A meal may contain:

> several dishes.

Example:

> soup is a dish

> soup + main + dessert together form a meal.

DI. MEAL VS COURSE

course

one stage/part of a meal served separately.

meal

the entire eating occasion.

> three-course meal
> = three courses forming one meal.

DJ. MEAL VS SNACK

meal

normally more substantial and associated with a regular eating occasion.

snack

smaller amount eaten between or instead of meals.

Boundary is contextual rather than scientifically fixed.

A large snack can function as a meal for one person.

DK. MEAL VS BITE

a bite

informal small/light amount of food.

meal

normally fuller/substantial.

> grab a quick bite
> vs
> sit down for a meal.

DL. MEAL VS FEAST

meal

neutral.

feast

large, elaborate or celebratory meal.

Every feast is a meal in a broad sense, but most meals are not feasts.

DM. MEAL VS BANQUET

banquet

large formal ceremonial meal for many people.

meal

general everyday term.

DN. MEAL VS DINNER

meal

umbrella category.

dinner

specific named meal, though which meal it refers to varies by culture/household.

So:

> dinner is a meal

> meal is not necessarily dinner.

DO. MEAL VS LUNCH

Same relationship:

> lunch is one kind of meal.

DP. MEAL VS MENU

You mapped **menu** earlier.

menu

list of food choices/planned dishes.

meal

food actually eaten/served on one occasion.

> choose from the menu → eat the meal.

DQ. MEAL VS SERVING

serving

quantity allocated to one person or one portion.

meal

entire eating occasion.

One meal may contain several servings of different foods.

DR. MEAL VS PORTION

portion

amount of a particular food.

meal

overall food/event.

> a portion of rice

> part of a meal.

DS. MEAL VS COMBO / SET

combo/set meal

commercial combination of specified items.

meal

need not be sold as a package.

DT. MEAL VS DIET

meal

one eating occasion.

diet

overall habitual pattern of food consumption.

A healthy meal does not automatically imply a healthy overall diet.

DU. MEAL VS NUTRITION

meal

food occasion.

nutrition

process/quality of obtaining and using nutrients.

Not synonymous.

DV. MEAL REPLACEMENT VS SUPPLEMENT

meal replacement

designed to stand in for a meal.

supplement

adds to ordinary dietary intake.

A nutritional supplement is not automatically a meal replacement.

DW. READY MEAL VS TAKEAWAY

ready meal

preprepared packaged food, usually heated at home.

takeaway/takeout meal

prepared by a restaurant and taken away for immediate eating.

DX. MEAL KIT VS READY MEAL

meal kit

ingredients + instructions; user cooks.

ready meal

largely/pre-fully prepared; user mainly reheats.

DY. MEAL PLAN VS MENU

menu

what is offered at a particular meal/restaurant.

meal plan

structured arrangement for several meals or prepaid dining access.

DZ. MAIN MEAL VS BIGGEST MEAL

Often overlap:

> main meal

usually means the day's most substantial meal, but can also mean the central meal socially.

EA. SQUARE MEAL VS BALANCED MEAL

square meal

substantial, satisfying, “proper” meal.

balanced meal

nutritionally balanced.

A square meal is not automatically nutritionally balanced.

EB. GRAMMAR

116. **a meal**

Countable in the food/eating sense:

> a meal

> three meals.

117. **have/eat a meal**

> have a meal with friends.

118. **meal of + food**

> “a meal of rice and vegetables”

= 一餐以米飯和蔬菜為主.

119. **meal for + person/group**

> prepare a meal for ten guests.

120. **meal at + time/place**

> a meal at noon

> a meal at a restaurant.

121. **over/during a meal**

> “We discussed business over a meal.”

「我們一邊吃飯一邊談生意。」

122. **between meals**

Fixed plural construction.

EC. COUNTABILITY: MEAL¹

The eating sense is normally **countable**:

> one meal

> two meals

> three meals a day.

ED. COUNTABILITY: MEAL²

The ground-material sense is normally **uncountable**:

> some cornmeal

> bone meal

> fish meal.

Not ordinarily:

> *two meals* meaning two portions of ground grain.

EE. NO NORMAL GENERAL VERB “MEAL”

For ordinary modern English:

> **meal** is primarily a noun.

Do not normally say:

> *We mealed at seven.* ❌

Use:

- * ate;
- * had dinner;
- * had a meal.

There have been historical/dialectal verbal uses connected with eating or grinding, but they are not useful active modern standard English and should remain archival rather than core learner entries.

EF. HISTORICAL MEAL = TIME / OCCASION

The ancestry of **meal¹** was broader than food.

Its Old English ancestor could mean:

> fixed time / occasion / appointed time.

That meaning survives historically in forms related to **piecemeal**, where the **-meal** element originally meant approximately “at a time / by portions.” ([詞源網絡詞典][1])

This is **not** a productive modern independent meaning of **meal**, but it explains some otherwise strange historical formations.

EG. PIECEMEAL — ETYMOLOGICAL RELATIVE ONLY

123. **piecemeal = piece by piece / gradually**

The **meal** in **piecemeal** is historically related to **meal¹ = occasion/time**, not to:

- * dinner;

* cornmeal.

Modern speakers do not analyze **piecemeal** as a normal compound containing the present-day word **meal**, so I would **not** count it as an ordinary modern meal-family sense—only as an etymological note. ([詞源網絡詞典][9])

EH. FAMILY MAP

Family member / branch	Main meaning
-----	-----
meal¹ — occasion	one occasion of eating
meal¹ — food	food eaten/served on that occasion
meal¹ — commercial unit	substantial prepared food offering sold as a meal
mealtime	customary/specified time for eating
meal plan — dietary	planned schedule/content of meals
meal plan — institutional	prepaid entitlement to specified dining
meal prep	preparing meals in advance
meal kit	ingredients/instructions for cooking a meal
ready meal	prepared packaged meal requiring little more than reheating
meal replacement	product designed to substitute for an ordinary meal
meal break	work break intended for eating
meal allowance	money provided to cover meal costs
meal ticket — literal	ticket exchangeable for a meal
meal ticket — figurative	dependable source of livelihood/income
make a meal of X	BrE: make unnecessarily much fuss/work of X
meal²	coarsely ground/crushed substance
cornmeal/oatmeal/etc.	ground cereal/nut products
soybean/fish/bone meal	processed feed/fertilizer material
mealy	powdery/floury/dry in texture
mealiness	mealy quality
mealworm	larva associated historically with stored meal/grain
mealy-mouthed	unwilling to speak plainly; fixed opaque adjective

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
meal — eating occasion	一次正式 / 通常較完整的進食場合；一餐
meal — food	某一餐實際吃 / 供應的整體食物
have/eat a meal	吃一頓飯
serve a meal	供應 / 端上一餐
sell meals	售賣可以構成一餐的餐食
skip a meal	有意不吃某一餐
miss a meal	因情況而沒有吃到某一餐

between meals	兩個正常用餐時段之間	
mealtime	正常 / 指定的用餐時間	
main meal	一天中最主要 / 最豐盛的一餐	
hot/cold meal	熱食 / 冷餐	
light meal	份量較小或較清淡的一餐	
heavy meal	份量大、豐富或較難消化的一餐	
substantial/full meal	足以令人飽足、較完整的正餐	
square meal	足量、像樣、能令人吃飽的一餐	
balanced meal	各主要營養成分較均衡的一餐	
home-cooked meal	在家自行烹調的一餐	
three-course meal	由三道依次供應的菜構成的一餐	
one-pot meal	大部分食材在同一鍋中完成的完整餐食	
family meal — household	家人共同吃的一餐	
family meal — restaurant	餐廳為員工準備、大家一起吃的員工餐	
staff meal	僱主 / 餐廳提供給員工的一餐	
ready meal	已預先煮好 / 製好，只需簡單加熱的即食餐	
frozen/microwave meal	冷凍 / 微波即食餐	
meal kit	按食譜配好食材、讓顧客自行烹調的料理包	
meal prep	預先一次準備多餐或多份食材的備餐做法	
meal planning	預先安排未來數餐吃甚麼的膳食規劃	
meal plan — diet	按日 / 週規劃的膳食安排	
meal plan — institution	學校 / 宿舍等預付後可享用指定餐數的餐飲方案	
meal service	為乘客、學生、病人等提供膳食的服務	
meal delivery	把準備好的餐食送到顧客 / 有需要人士所在地	
Meals on Wheels	為行動或自理能力有限人士提供送餐的服務	
meal replacement	設計為代替一頓普通膳食的產品；代餐	
meal deal	幾件食物 / 飲品以一個優惠價格組合出售的套餐	
set meal	以固定組合 / 有限選擇出售的一份套餐	
school meal	在學校提供 / 進食的膳食	
airline meal	航班上供應的航空餐	
meal break/period	工作期間供員工吃飯的休息時間	
meal allowance	僱主等提供的膳食津貼	
meal voucher	可用於換取 / 支付餐食的餐券	
meal ticket — literal	可憑票換取一餐的餐票	
meal ticket — figurative	某人賴以維持生活的穩定收入來源 / 「飯票」	
make a meal of X — idiom	BrE：把簡單事情弄得過分繁複、花過多力氣；小題大做	
meal ² — powder	穀物、種子等磨成的較粗粉狀物	
cornmeal	磨碎玉米製成的玉米粗粉	
oatmeal — material	磨碎 / 加工的燕麥製品；在 AmE 亦常指燕麥粥	
wholemeal	BrE：使用整粒穀物研磨製成的全麥 / 全穀產品	
soybean meal	榨油後常作飼料的豆粕	
oilseed meal	油籽榨油後留下的蛋白質豐富粉粕	
fish meal	由魚類 / 魚副產品製成的乾燥魚粉	
bone meal	磨碎骨頭製成、常作肥料等用途的骨粉	
blood meal ^{2}	乾燥研磨血液產品，如作肥料 / 飼料原料	
blood meal ^{1}	吸血昆蟲 / 動物一次以血為食的進食	

meat-and-bone meal	經處理的動物肉骨粉產品	
mealy	口感 / 表面像粉一樣乾鬆、粉質的	
mealy potato/apple	肉質粉鬆的薯仔 / 變得粉粉不爽脆的蘋果	
mealiness	食物呈粉質、乾鬆的特性	
mealworm	黃粉蟲幼蟲 / 麵包蟲	
mealybug	表面有白色粉蠟物的植物害蟲；粉蚧	
mealy-mouthed	不敢直接表明立場、說話過分含糊委婉的	

For your original passage

> “...calculate how many cups of coffee and **meals** you must sell each day to break even.”

Here, **meal** is functioning almost as a **business sales unit**:

> one customer buys a substantial food order → one meal sale.

It deliberately contrasts with:

> **cup of coffee**

because the writer wants Kam Chai to stop thinking only in terms of atmosphere and start asking:

> How much revenue does each customer generate?

> How many transactions do we need?

> How many coffees?

> How many meals?

So the semantic progression continues:

> **dream** → aspiration

> **target** → measurable endpoint

> **calculate** → numerical analysis

> **meal** → actual saleable unit generating revenue.

A strong Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> **「計算每天到底要售出多少杯咖啡和多少份餐食，才能做到收支平衡。」**

For your core database, I would keep **3 principal semantic cores**:

1. **meal¹**: an eating occasion and, metonymically, the food eaten/served at it

2. **meal²**: coarse ground/crushed grain, seed, animal material, etc.

3. **figurative lexicalized extensions from meal¹**, especially ***meal ticket*** and ***make a meal of something***

Then separately index the high-value compounds **mealtime**, **ready meal**, **meal kit**, **meal prep**,

meal plan, meal replacement, meal deal, square meal, meal break, meal allowance, meal ticket, cornmeal, oatmeal, soybean meal, fish meal, bone meal, mealworm, mealy, and mealy-mouthed**. The two base nouns **meal¹** and **meal²** should stay visibly separate because their identical spelling is historical coincidence rather than ordinary semantic extension. ([詞源網絡詞典][1])

[1]: https://www.etymonline.com/word/meal?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Meal - Etymology, Origin & Meaning"

[2]: https://dictionary.cambridge.org/us/dictionary/english/meal?utm_source=chatgpt.com "MEAL | definition in the Cambridge English Dictionary"

[3]: https://www.etymonline.com/word/mealtime?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Mealtime - Etymology, Origin & Meaning"

[4]: https://dictionary.cambridge.org/us/dictionary/learner-english/meal?utm_source=chatgpt.com "MEAL | definition in the Cambridge Learner's Dictionary"

[5]: https://dictionary.cambridge.org/us/dictionary/english/meal-ticket?utm_source=chatgpt.com "MEAL TICKET | definition in the Cambridge English Dictionary"

[6]: https://www.collinsdictionary.com/us/dictionary/english/make-a-meal-of-something?utm_source=chatgpt.com "MAKE A MEAL OF STH definition in American English | Collins English Dictionary"

[7]: https://www.etymonline.com/word/oatmeal?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Oatmeal - Etymology, Origin & Meaning"

[8]: https://www.etymonline.com/word/meal-worm?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Meal-worm - Etymology, Origin & Meaning"

[9]: https://www.etymonline.com/word/piecemeal?utm_source=chatgpt.com "Piecemeal - Etymology, Origin & Meaning"